The Aliya Money Checklist

A money checklist for Americans planning Aliya, organized by time horizon

Many Aliya money decisions work best when started early. This checklist is organized by time horizon. Each item is something to review, organize, or plan, often with a qualified professional such as a cross-border CPA, Israeli counsel, or a US investment adviser. Rules change, and every family's situation is different.

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1. Planning a Move in the Future (Several Years Out)

- [ ] Set a target move date and estimate the cash you will need around the move.
- [ ] Ask a cross-border CPA which accounts (retirement, Roth, or taxable) to favor for new savings, since US tax-free treatment may not carry over to Israel.
- [ ] Ask each US firm whether it limits buying certain investments, such as some mutual funds, for clients living abroad. Restrictions vary by firm and by country of residence.
- [ ] Consider setting aside funds over time for expected shekel expenses (rent, tuition, daily costs). Currency swings can change what those funds buy, and currency hedging has costs and may not prevent losses.
- [ ] Organize your tax returns, account statements, and cost basis records.
- [ ] Review your life insurance coverage while still a US resident, and check each policy's rules for living abroad, since coverage may be harder to arrange after a move.
- [ ] Review whether your wills, beneficiary designations, and guardianship choices are up to date.
- [ ] Line up a cross-border CPA, Israeli counsel, and a US investment adviser.

2. About a Year Out

- [ ] Confirm your bank's and brokerage's policy on non-US addresses.
- [ ] List all your accounts and decide whether consolidating any of them would simplify tracking and paperwork across two countries.
- [ ] Confirm with a CPA your US filing obligations after the move (US citizens generally continue to file US tax returns wherever they live) and whether any state may still treat you as a resident.
- [ ] Confirm Israel's current tax benefits for new immigrants, and the reporting rules, with Israeli counsel or an Israeli CPA, since they have changed in recent years.
- [ ] Ask US and Israeli tax professionals how the tax treaty and the timing of selling investments, a home, or a business affect your taxes before you act.
- [ ] Review your options for existing 401(k) and IRA accounts, and your employer plan's rules for participants living abroad.
- [ ] Compare the tax, cost, and risk of each way to fund a down payment (cash, selling investments, or an Israeli mortgage), and ask a cross-border CPA how each is treated in the US and Israel.

3. In the Final Months Before the Move

- [ ] Set up a way to receive two-factor login codes in Israel to help avoid being locked out of your accounts.
- [ ] Ask each institution whether it requires a US mailing address, and review your options and their implications, including for state residency, with a CPA.
- [ ] Do a final review of beneficiaries on your retirement, insurance, and brokerage accounts, and consider a power of attorney for someone you trust to act on your US accounts.
- [ ] Plan for possible gaps between your US health coverage ending and your Israeli coverage starting.
- [ ] Set aside an accessible emergency reserve in a mix of currencies.
- [ ] Check your earnings record at ssa.gov and read the Social Security Administration's guidance on receiving payments abroad.
- [ ] Make secure, accessible copies of your tax returns, account statements, cost basis records, and key documents.

4. The First Months After Arriving

- [ ] Ask a cross-border CPA whether you need to file an FBAR (FinCEN Form 114), FATCA Form 8938, or both for your Israeli accounts.
- [ ] Check with a cross-border CPA before investing in non-US funds through an Israeli account, since many non-US funds can trigger complex and costly US tax treatment for US taxpayers.
- [ ] Compare exchange rates and fees across banks and transfer services before each transfer.
- [ ] Review your estate documents with US and Israeli counsel once you are a resident.
- [ ] Compare your actual living costs with your projections, and review whether your investment plan and cash reserve need updating.

Next Step

Aliya Financial LLC is a fee-based investment adviser that manages US investment accounts for people preparing to move to Israel, and coordinates with their CPAs and attorneys.

Request a free consultation at aliyafinancial.com

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